

NORTHWEST CUSTOM APPAREL

Employee Handbook

Effective May 26, 2026 · Revised July 10, 2026

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Welcome

Effective May 26, 2026 · last revised July 10, 2026 — added: Washington PFML (Ch 13), WA Cares Fund (Ch 19), workplace-injury & workers'-comp reporting (Ch 18), pregnancy/lactation and disability/religious accommodations (Ch 9). Living document — last updated by Erik via the Policies Hub.

Welcome to Northwest Custom Apparel. This is our Employee Handbook — the single source of truth for our policies, expectations, and workplace standards. It is a living document: chapters are updated as policies evolve, and the full handbook is reviewed annually each January.

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How this handbook works

- **Living document:** chapters are updated as policies evolve. Each chapter shows its own “last updated” date.
- **Authority:** where this handbook and a specific Policies Hub policy disagree, the more recent document wins. Detailed policies (Flex Time, Vacation Scheduling, etc.) layer additional rules on top of the handbook foundation.
- **Annual refresh:** a full handbook review is done each January, with employee acknowledgment.
- **Suggestions or concerns:** talk to Erik directly or via Slack DM.

Chapter 1: Welcome to Northwest Custom Apparel

Welcome letter from Erik Mickelson, Operations Manager. Sets the tone for what NWCA is about: a family, a community, and a commitment to quality and customer WOW.

From the Operations Manager

Dear New Team Member,

I'm Erik Mickelson, your Operations Manager, and it's my pleasure to welcome you to our family. Here at Northwest Custom Apparel, we live by values that make us more than just a company — we're a community. These values — Respect, Excellence, Accountability, Compassion, and Honesty — are the threads that bind us together, much like the threads that have been part of my life since I was a three-year-old watching my father, Jim, pour his heart into this business.

At Northwest Custom Apparel, we believe in 'Wowing' our customers with our exceptional custom apparel and unparalleled customer service. This commitment to excellence is deeply embedded in our motto: **"Be Nice, Tell the Truth, and always strive for the Best Day Ever."** This ethos has been a guiding star for us, passed down from my father, who showed that kindness and hard work are the cornerstones of success.

We understand that skills can be taught, but a good attitude is innate. Our management style is laid-back, fostering mutual respect and open communication. Remember, there's no such thing as a dumb question here. We value good attendance and encourage you never to hesitate to seek support or guidance. We're not a faceless corporate entity; we're a team, a family, committed to helping each other grow personally and professionally.

As you embark on your journey with us, remember our rallying cry: **"Let's have the best day ever!"** Every day is an opportunity to create something unique, to bring a 'WOW' to someone's life. We're thrilled to have you on board and can't wait to see the incredible things we'll achieve together.

Welcome to the team, where every day is an opportunity to weave excellence into the fabric of our work and our lives.

Warm regards,

Erik Mickelson

Operations Manager

Chapter 2: Our History

NWCA was founded in 1977 as Northwest Embroidery. From caps for the Alaska Pipeline to a full-service custom apparel decorator in the Seattle/Tacoma area.

Founded in 1977

Northwest Custom Apparel began as Northwest Embroidery, a brainchild of Jim Mickelson. The idea germinated while Jim worked on the Alaska Pipeline, where he saw the potential in selling embroidered caps to his colleagues. This marked the inception of our journey as pioneers in the custom embroidery and apparel industry.

Expanding Horizons

From its humble beginnings, our company has grown significantly. Our core services now span custom embroidery, Direct-to-Garment (DTG) printing, and screen printing — and in 2026 we expanded again, adding laser engraving for drinkware and leatherette patches, plus a Roland wide-format printer that produces banners and stickers in-house. We're proud to be recognized as leaders in these fields in the Seattle and Tacoma areas.

Commitment to Customer Service

Since our inception, we have upheld a solid commitment to **“old-fashioned customer service,”** a principle deeply rooted in our founder's vision. This approach has earned us a reputation for delivering the “WOW” factor in every customer interaction, characterized by quality service and timely delivery.

Innovation and Sustainability

Embracing innovation has always been at the forefront of our operations. We have ventured into the future of apparel decoration with direct-to-garment printing, investing in cutting-edge technology and environmentally friendly practices. Using water-based inks in our Kornit printers exemplifies our commitment to sustainability.

A Family and Team-Oriented Culture

At Northwest Custom Apparel, we cherish family values and a team-oriented culture. This ethos has cultivated a supportive and collaborative work environment integral to our success and growth.

Looking Forward

As we continue to evolve, our focus remains on exploring new services, products, and ideas to stay at the forefront of the industry. Our journey is a testament to our adaptability, dedication to quality, and unwavering commitment to customer satisfaction.

Chapter 3: Mission Statement

Northwest Custom Apparel is committed to delivering happiness and creating WOW moments for every customer. Mission, what we aim for, what guides every decision.

“Northwest Custom Apparel is committed to delivering happiness and creating WOW moments for every customer.”

At Northwest Custom Apparel, our mission goes beyond fulfilling customer needs — we aim to **exceed expectations**. This commitment is evident in our efforts to:

- **Deliver Happiness:** Every customer interaction is an opportunity to spread joy and positivity.
- **Create WOW Moments:** We consistently aim to exceed the ordinary, impress our customers, and set new industry standards.
- **Foster Excellence in Service:** Our team is driven by the pursuit of exceptional service, ensuring every customer experience is memorable.

How the mission connects to your day

The mission isn't a poster on the wall. It shows up in every customer call, every job ticket, every shirt that goes out the door. When you're deciding how to handle a tough situation, the question is always: *does this create happiness or a WOW moment for the customer?* When the answer is yes, you're aligned. When the answer is no, find a different path.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Operating Principles, Core Values & Vision 2026

Chapter 4: Core Values 2026

Our five Core Values for 2026, with operational taglines and the sample phrases staff actually say. Respect, Excellence, Accountability, Compassion, Honesty.

*The 2024 Employee Handbook listed our Core Values as five abstract words. The 2026 version expands each with a **tagline** (what the value means) and the **sample phrases** staff actually say when living it.*

Value	Tagline	Sample phrases staff actually say
Respect	We Lift Each Other Up.	“Help out.” “We’re in this together.”
Excellence	We Figure It Out.	“We’ll sort this out.”
Accountability	We Own The Outcome.	“What can we take away from this?”
Compassion	We Protect Our People.	“Your well-being is important to us.”
Honesty	We Close The Loop.	“I appreciate your honesty.”

Each value, in detail

Respect — We Lift Each Other Up

We treat customers and coworkers with utmost respect, actively listen to their needs, and provide tailored services regardless of the order size. The smallest order from the newest customer gets the same attention as the biggest contract from our largest account.

Excellence — We Figure It Out

Our commitment to continuous improvement, embracing innovation, and adapting to evolving customer needs ensures we remain at the forefront of our industry. When something is broken or unclear, we don’t complain — we fix it or escalate it.

Accountability — We Own The Outcome

We take responsibility for our actions, swiftly address mistakes, and focus on finding solutions. Through proactive communication and collaboration, we strive to preempt challenges. Mistakes are inevitable — hiding them is what damages trust.

Compassion — We Protect Our People

We foster a supportive workplace where empathy and understanding prevail, creating a safe space for team members to express their ideas and concerns. Family emergencies, illness, hard days — we have each other’s backs.

Honesty — We Close The Loop

Upholding transparency and ethical conduct, we prioritize the interests of our customers and colleagues alike. When you make a commitment, you follow through — or you communicate why you can’t and reset expectations.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Operating Principles, Core Values & Vision 2026

Chapter 5: The Five Operating Principles

How we work day-to-day. Five numbered principles reinforced in every Tuesday All-Hands meeting. The operational expectations behind every Core Value.

*These five principles describe **how we work**. They are the operational expectations behind every Core Value. Memorize them — they are reinforced in every Tuesday All-Hands meeting.*

1. **Hand off the job so clean the next person never has to guess.** Do your job all the way to the finish line. The next person picking up your work shouldn't have to investigate, ask around, or guess what you did or why.
2. **Adapt. Improve. Deliver.** Plans change. Customers change. The exact path to the outcome will shift. The outcome itself doesn't.
3. **Own mistakes immediately.** Wrong thread color? Tell Ruthie now — before the customer ever sees it. Speed of acknowledgment matters more than perfection. We can fix what we know about; we can't fix what's hidden.
4. **See the load. Share the load.** When you see a coworker drowning, you don't need permission to step in. When you're drowning, ask. Pretending everything is fine when it isn't hurts the team.
5. **Silence breaks trust. Speak up.** If something's wrong, say so. If something could be better, say so. If you don't understand, say so. Silent disagreement and silent confusion both compound into bigger problems.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Operating Principles, Core Values & Vision 2026

Chapter 6: Vision 2026

Where we are going. People you know, quality you trust. \$3M target. Trust is our currency. The showroom is where it happens. We play the long game.

Headline

People You Know. Quality You Trust.

The workplace we're building

A proactive and positive workplace that delivers WOW. A safe, high-trust environment where we shield each other from politics and communicate with the same kindness we show our best customers. This environment inspires creativity and WOW moments — a space where all ideas are welcomed and questions are always encouraged.

The heart of customer connection

People buy from people they know, like, and trust. Our showroom is where we make those connections happen. It is a welcoming space designed for us to become friends, and touch and feel the latest styles together. We focus on being nice and building the relationship first.

Strategic growth: trust is our currency

We are targeting **\$3.0M in 2026**, but we won't reach that goal by chasing transactions. **We play the long game.** We'll reach our goal by turning every visitor into a friend who knows, likes, and trusts us. When we focus on the relationship first, the sales follow naturally.

How Vision, Values, and Principles fit together

- The **Vision** tells you where we're going.
- The **Core Values** tell you what we stand for on the way.
- The **Operating Principles** tell you how we behave day-to-day.

You don't pick one. They're a stack. The Vision sets direction; the Values pick the route; the Principles drive the car.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Operating Principles, Core Values & Vision 2026

Chapter 7: Employment Basics

At-will employment, equal employment opportunity, and employment categories (Full-Time, Part-Time, Temporary).

Employee “At-Will” Statement

Employment at Northwest Custom Apparel is “**at-will**,” meaning either the employee or the company can terminate employment at any time for any reason. This status can only be altered in writing by the President/CEO.

Commitment to Equal Opportunity

We are committed to equal employment opportunities, ensuring fairness and diversity in all employment practices, including recruitment, hiring, training, promotions, compensation, and benefits, without discrimination based on race, color, religion, sex, national origin, age, disability, or any protected status.

Employment Categories

1. **Full-Time Employees:** These employees work a standard workweek, typically 40 hours. After completing their 90-day probationary period, they become eligible for the full range of company benefits.
2. **Part-Time Employees:** Employees in this category regularly work fewer than 40 hours per week. Being part-time may impact their eligibility for certain company benefits.
3. **Temporary Employees:** Hired for a specific, limited period, temporary employees generally do not qualify for most company benefits. Their employment concludes with the end of their assignment.

Note: These categories are set for clarity on expectations and benefits but do not change the at-will nature of employment.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Flex Time Policy 2026
- Reinstatement & Rehire Policy — 30-Day Window

Chapter 8: Code of Conduct & Conflict of Interest

Professional standards, workplace behavior, and the requirement to disclose conflicts of interest.

Professional Standards and Integrity

At Northwest Custom Apparel, we hold a high standard for professional behavior. This includes:

- Exhibiting respect and cooperation towards colleagues and customers.
- Diligently and ethically fulfilling job responsibilities.
- Upholding the company's image positively, both within and outside the workplace.

Workplace Behavior

Our commitment is to foster a respectful and inclusive environment. **Any form of harassment, discrimination, or bullying is unacceptable and will result in disciplinary action.** We prioritize maintaining a workplace where everyone feels valued and safe.

Conflict of Interest

Avoiding Conflicts

Employees must avoid situations or activities that could cause or seem to cause a conflict of interest. This includes personal or financial interests that might compromise or appear to compromise your impartial decision-making for the company.

Reporting Obligations

Any potential conflicts should be immediately disclosed to a supervisor or to Erik. **Openness is critical to effectively addressing these issues and upholding trust.**

Related Policies Hub entries

- Operating Principles, Core Values & Vision 2026

Chapter 9: Diversity & Inclusion

NWCA's diversity and inclusion commitments: inclusive recruitment, training, zero tolerance for discrimination, and recognition of our diverse workforce.

At Northwest Custom Apparel, we are committed to fostering a diverse and inclusive workplace. Our policy focuses on:

1. **Inclusive Recruitment:** We aim for a hiring process that reflects our diverse community, valuing skills and potential over background.
2. **Education and Training:** Regular diversity and inclusion training sessions are provided to all employees to nurture a respectful work environment.
3. **Zero Tolerance for Discrimination or Harassment:** We strictly enforce policies against discrimination and harassment and are committed to addressing any issues swiftly and fairly.
4. **Celebrating Diversity:** We proudly recognize the diversity of our workforce, including members from Thai, Cambodian, and various other backgrounds, and we continuously strive to uphold an environment where this diversity is celebrated and every individual feels valued.
5. **Open Door Policy:** Erik Mickelson's open door policy serves as a primary channel for employees to report concerns related to discrimination or harassment, ensuring a safe and welcoming workplace for all.
6. **Regular Policy Review:** This policy is subject to ongoing review to ensure it effectively meets the evolving needs of our employees and workplace.

Pregnancy, Lactation & New Parents

Because NWCA has 15 or more employees, Washington's Healthy Starts Act guarantees pregnant employees reasonable accommodations. Some are automatic — no doctor's note required, and NWCA will not claim hardship:

- more frequent or longer restroom breaks;
- keeping food and water at or near your workstation;
- seating, or more frequent opportunities to sit;
- limits on lifting more than 17 pounds.

Other accommodations — schedule changes, temporary transfer to lighter duty, limits on strenuous work, time off for prenatal visits, or anything else that helps — will be worked out with Erik; for some of these, the law allows us to request supporting information from your provider.

Lactation. Nursing employees receive reasonable break time to express milk for up to two years after the child's birth, and a clean, private space that is not a bathroom, with seating and a flat surface — arranged with Erik. Coordinate timing with Erik or Ruthie so production coverage works; these breaks run with, not against, your normal paid breaks wherever possible.

Asking for any accommodation in this section will never be held against you.

Reasonable Accommodations — Disability & Religion

NWCA is covered by the Washington Law Against Discrimination and the ADA, and we provide reasonable accommodations for disabilities and for sincerely held religious beliefs and practices.

How to ask: tell Erik — or any supervisor, who will bring it to Erik — that you need a change at work because of a medical condition or a religious belief or practice. No special form and no magic words are required.

What happens next (the interactive process):

1. We talk promptly and in good faith about what's limiting you and what might help.

2. For medical accommodations we may request reasonable documentation from your provider. It stays confidential and is kept separate from your personnel file.
3. We implement an effective accommodation unless it would create an undue hardship — and if the first idea doesn't work, we keep looking together.

Examples: modified schedules; equipment or workstation changes; reassignment of non-essential tasks; unpaid leave as an accommodation; dress, grooming, or scheduling adjustments for religious practice. Retaliation for requesting an accommodation is prohibited.

Chapter 10: Workplace Bullying & Harassment

Zero-tolerance policy for bullying and harassment. Definitions, reporting mechanism, confidentiality, investigation process, and protection from retaliation.

Purpose

This policy establishes a zero-tolerance stance towards bullying and harassment in the workplace. We are committed to providing all employees with a safe, respectful, and inclusive work environment.

Scope

This policy applies to all employees, contractors, interns, and volunteers at Northwest Custom Apparel.

Policy Statement

1. Zero Tolerance for Bullying and Harassment

Northwest Custom Apparel does not tolerate any form of bullying or harassment. This includes but is not limited to verbal, physical, psychological, and online behaviors that intimidate, offend, degrade, or humiliate another person.

2. Definitions

- **Bullying:** Unwanted behavior that makes someone feel intimidated, degraded, humiliated, or offended. It is not necessarily related to an individual's protected characteristics and can be a pattern of behavior or a single incident.
- **Harassment:** Unwanted conduct related to a protected characteristic (such as age, sex, race, disability, religion or belief, sexual orientation, etc.) that violates an individual's dignity or creates an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating, or offensive environment.

3. Reporting Mechanism

- **Open Door Policy:** Erik Mickelson, Operations Manager, maintains an open-door policy. Employees are encouraged to report any incident of bullying or harassment to him directly.
- **Confidentiality:** All reports will be treated with strict confidentiality. We understand the sensitive nature of these issues and will ensure discretion throughout the process.

4. Investigation Process

An impartial and thorough investigation will be conducted upon receiving a complaint. All involved parties will have an opportunity to be heard.

5. Protection from Retaliation

Employees who complain or participate in investigations are protected from retaliation. **Any form of retaliation will result in disciplinary action.**

6. Disciplinary Actions

Violations of this policy will be met with appropriate disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment.

7. Prevention and Training

Regular training and awareness programs will educate employees on recognizing and preventing workplace bullying and harassment.

Conclusion

Northwest Custom Apparel is dedicated to maintaining a work environment where everyone is treated with respect and dignity. Bullying and harassment have no place in our workplace, and we all have a responsibility to uphold these standards.

Chapter 11: Social Media Policy

Guidelines for responsible social media use by NWCA employees, both inside and outside work. Confidentiality, professionalism, representation, and reporting concerns.

Purpose

This policy provides guidelines for appropriate and responsible social media use by Northwest Custom Apparel employees, both within and outside the workplace.

Scope

This policy applies to all employees of Northwest Custom Apparel, including full-time, part-time, and temporary staff.

Guidelines

1. **Responsible Use:** Employees are encouraged to use social media responsibly. Remember that your posts and actions online can reflect on Northwest Custom Apparel and affect our company's image.
2. **Respect Privacy:** Be mindful of the privacy and confidentiality of company information. **Do not share confidential or proprietary information** about Northwest Custom Apparel, our clients, or our partners.
3. **Professionalism:** While using social media, maintain professionalism and respect towards colleagues, clients, and the company. Inappropriate or offensive content can negatively impact the work environment and the company's reputation.
4. **Personal Social Media Accounts:** When connecting with coworkers on personal social media accounts, exercise discretion. Be aware that the content you share on your personal platforms, especially content that may contradict our core values of Respect, Excellence, Accountability, Compassion, and Honesty, can influence professional relationships and perceptions in the workplace.
5. **Representation:** If you identify yourself as an employee of Northwest Custom Apparel on any social media platform, add a disclaimer stating that your views are your own and do not represent those of the company.
6. **Compliance with Policies:** Your conduct on social media should comply with all company policies, including anti-discrimination, confidentiality, and workplace conduct.
7. **Reporting Concerns:** If you encounter content on social media that raises concerns or conflicts with our policies, please report it to your supervisor or to Erik.

Consequences of Violations

Violating this social media policy may result in disciplinary action, including termination of employment.

Chapter 12: Work Conditions & Hours

Workweek and shift definitions, timekeeping, breaks, lunch periods, tardiness, and remote work standards. Layered with Flex Time Policy 2026 for shifted schedules.

Standard Workweek & Shifts

- **Day Shift (Production):** 8:00 AM – 4:30 PM, including a mandatory 30-minute lunch break.
- **Salaried Office / Art Staff:** 8:00 AM – 5:00 PM, with a 60-minute lunch break.
- **Management:** 8:00 AM – 5:00 PM, 60-minute lunch break included.
- **Hourly Office Staff:** 8:00 AM – 4:30 PM, 30-minute lunch break.
- **Work Week Definition:** Monday 12:01 AM to Sunday Noon. Overtime is determined for hours exceeding 40 within this period.

Salaried office staff may have approved Shifted Start or Reduced Hours arrangements per the Flex Time Policy 2026.

Timekeeping

- **Clocking In/Out:** The TimeClick system is mandatory to record work hours.
- **Quarter-Hour Increments:** Timekeeping is in 15-minute intervals.
- **Late Arrivals / Early Departures:** Must be logged and reported to your supervisor for proper documentation.
- **Missed Punches:** Must be reported immediately to Ruthie (production manager) or to accounting for rectification.

Breaks & Lunch Periods

- **Regular Breaks:** Two 10-minute breaks per shift, staggered as per the department's operational flow. (paid)
- **Lunch Break Compliance:** Strict adherence to lunch break times is required. Lunch cannot be used to offset late arrivals or early departures. (unpaid)

For details on the lunch break rules, the Voluntary Meal Period Waiver, and WA labor law specifics, see the Lunch Break Policy & Voluntary Meal Period Waiver.

Tardiness

- **Punctuality:** Employees must punch in on time and immediately start work. Non-work activities, like making coffee or socializing, are not permitted after punching in.
- **Grace Period:** Occasionally, a 5–10 minute grace period is allowed due to unforeseen circumstances like traffic or bad weather. Habitual tardiness (2–3 times a month) will lead to progressive disciplinary action.
- **Lunch & Breaks:** A 5-minute occasional grace period for returning late from lunch. Breaks are strictly 10 minutes and start/end at the workstation.
- **Absenteeism:** Clear communication of absences is mandatory. Unreported absences can lead to termination.

Remote Work Attendance

- **Expectations:** Regular check-ins and availability during work hours are mandatory. Must be reachable via phone, Slack, or email.

Emergency & Personal Time Off

- **Unexpected Circumstances:** Requires immediate notification and supervisor's approval.
- **Personal Appointments:** Encouraged to be scheduled outside working hours. If needed during work hours, advance notice is required.

Disciplinary Actions for Policy Violation

- **Consistent Violations:** Progressive discipline approach, including warnings, written reprimands, and potential termination.
- **No-Call, No-Show:** Considered a severe violation with immediate termination potential.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Flex Time Policy 2026
- Lunch Break Policy & Voluntary Meal Period Waiver

Chapter 13: Leave & Time Off

Vacation accrual, sick leave (WA state law), maternity/paternity, emergency leave, bereavement, LWOP, jury duty, voting, reporting absences.

General Overview

We offer flexible leave options to balance employee needs with operational efficiency.

Vacation Leave

- **Eligibility:** Full-time employees after one year.
- **Accrual:** 1 week after one year, 2 weeks after three years.
- **Request Process:** Submit in writing two weeks prior — see the Vacation Scheduling Policy 2026 for the full request workflow.
- **Approval:** Based on workload; no simultaneous department vacations.
- **Unused Vacation:** Required to use annually; carryover requires Erik Mickelson's approval.

Tenure Recognition Package PTO bonuses: see Flex Time Policy 2026 §4.

Sick Leave

- **Accrual:** 1 hour per 40 hours worked (WA state law minimum).
- **Carryover:** Up to 40 hours annually.
- **When sick time runs out:** additional sick absences draw from vacation time; once both are exhausted, time missed is unpaid. For current balances, ask Erik — payroll provides an updated report every pay period.
- **Use:** For personal / family illness or medical needs.
- **Documentation:** Required for absences over three days.

Maternity / Paternity Leave

Follows Washington State law; job security is guaranteed post-leave.

Emergency Leave

- For urgent personal situations, up to two days, extendable with approval.
- Unpaid, but personal / vacation time can be used.

Bereavement Leave

- For immediate family loss, up to a week using personal / vacation time.
- Flexible extensions are possible.

Leave Without Pay (LWOP)

Requires two weeks' notice; subject to approval.

Jury Duty & Civic Participation

- Provide documentation for jury duty.
- Flexible time off for voting.

Leave Policy Violations

Absences beyond three days without notice may lead to termination.

Reporting Absences

- Text supervisor one hour before shift; follow text notifications with a call.
- Repeated tardiness can lead to disciplinary action.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Vacation Scheduling Policy 2026
- Flex Time Policy 2026
- Lunch Break Policy & Voluntary Meal Period Waiver
- Reinstatement & Rehire Policy — 30-Day Window

Paid Family & Medical Leave (Washington PFML)

Washington runs a statewide paid-leave insurance program that nearly every NWCA employee participates in automatically. You pay a small premium through payroll deduction (it appears on your paystub as PFML), and NWCA reports your hours and wages to the state each quarter.

What it covers. If you qualify, the state pays you a portion of your wages — up to a weekly maximum set by the state each year — while you take leave to:

- recover from your own serious health condition (medical leave);
- bond with a new child in the first year after birth, adoption, or foster placement;
- care for a family member with a serious health condition;
- handle certain events arising from a family member's military service.

How much time: generally up to 12 weeks per claim year of medical or family leave, up to 16 weeks combined, and up to 18 weeks when the combination includes incapacity related to pregnancy complications.

Who qualifies: anyone who worked at least 820 hours in Washington during the qualifying period (roughly the past year) — hours with any Washington employer count, not just NWCA.

How to use it:

1. Apply directly with the state — not through NWCA — at paidleave.wa.gov. The state decides eligibility and pays the benefit.
2. Give NWCA at least 30 days' written notice when the leave is foreseeable (birth, planned surgery), or notice as soon as practical in an emergency, so we can plan coverage (see *Team Coverage During Absences*).
3. Keep Erik updated on your expected return date while you're out.

Job protection & NWCA paid time off. Because NWCA has fewer than 50 employees, the automatic job-restoration provisions of PFML (and the federal FMLA) do not apply. Talk with Erik before your leave begins — we will discuss return expectations in good faith and put them in writing. PFML is separate from, and in addition to, your NWCA sick leave and vacation: using PFML does not use up your accrued sick leave, and state rules govern whether you may supplement PFML benefits with NWCA paid time off. Questions: paidleave.wa.gov, or ask Erik.

Chapter 14: Holiday Schedule

NWCA observed paid holidays plus manufacturing closure between Christmas and New Year.

Paid Holidays

Northwest Custom Apparel observes the following paid holidays:

- Memorial Day
- Independence Day
- Labor Day
- Thanksgiving Day
- Christmas Day
- New Year's Day

Year-End Manufacturing Closure

The manufacturing department will be closed the week between Christmas and New Year's. The sales, accounting, and art departments will remain open during this period.

***Full-time employees only receive holiday pay.**

Chapter 15: General Plant & Office Rules

Cell phones, visitors, personal work, confidentiality, company property, theft, building keys, smoking, food/beverages, electronics, cleanliness. Plus general office rules.

General Plant Rules

Cell Phone Policy

Personal cell phone calls are prohibited during work hours. Use cell phones on breaks in areas that do not disturb working employees.

Visitor Policy

Visitors must have prior approval to enter the plant. Friends and relatives should wait outside.

Children are not allowed in the factory for safety reasons.

Personal Work

All work performed in the plant must have an approved work order. Personal work must be done on the employee's own time and not during regular working hours.

Unauthorized Use

Unauthorized personal work is grounds for immediate termination. This includes using company resources for personal projects like embroidery, shirt printing, and artwork creation.

Confidentiality of Customer Lists

Work done in the plant, including production orders, designs, and customer inquiries, must remain confidential.

Company Property & Theft

- **Authorization Required:** Do not remove any items from the plant without approval from a department manager. This includes materials, damaged goods, cardboard boxes, designs, and other company property.
- **Theft Policy:** Theft of any kind is grounds for immediate discharge. All intellectual property remains the property of Northwest Custom Apparel.

Trash Disposal

Company dumpsters are for company trash only. Personal trash should not be brought to work for disposal.

Building Keys

- Certain employees may be assigned building keys for after-hours work. Family or friends are not allowed in the building during these times.
- **Loss of Keys:** Report lost keys immediately. Unauthorized access to areas in the building while alone is grounds for termination.

Workplace Communication

Casual conversations in work areas should be limited to business topics. Personal discussions should occur during breaks.

Safety First

Avoid distractions that could lead to accidents or errors. Focus on work tasks for safety and efficiency.

No Children in the Workplace

Due to the inherent safety hazards present in our embroidery factory, including moving machinery, needles, hot heat presses, and scissors, we must enforce a strict policy prohibiting children in the workplace at all times.

Pets in the Factory

Pets are not allowed in the factory area due to safety hazards. In the front office, well-behaved dogs and cats may visit occasionally, but for no longer than a day.

Smoking Policy

As of April 1, 2015, Northwest Custom Apparel is a **completely smoke-free campus**. This includes all areas of the premises and smoking in cars on the property.

Food and Beverages

Beverages and food are prohibited in the production area. In the office, drinks are allowed at desks, but no gum chewing or eating is permitted.

Use of Personal Electronics

Radios, stereos, Bluetooth cellphones, and iPods are not allowed in the production and main office areas. This rule ensures attention to machinery and safety.

Workplace Cleanliness

All employees are responsible for keeping their work areas, including machinery, desks, and floors, clean. Time is allocated on Fridays for thorough cleaning, alternating between day and graveyard shifts.

General Office Rules

1. **Attendance:** Your workday starts and ends at your desk. Be ready to assist customers with your computer turned on at the start of your shift.
2. **Use of Company Equipment:** Company equipment is for work purposes. Personal internet browsing, online shopping, and social media are permitted only during breaks and lunch.
3. **Confidentiality:** Customer lists, email addresses, and company paperwork are proprietary. Do not share this information outside the company.
4. **Noise and Distractions:** Keep music at a volume that does not disturb coworkers. Limit personal phone calls and texts. No watching videos or social media on your phone during work hours.
5. **Workspace Appearance:** Maintain a neat and professional workspace.
6. **Professional Conduct:** Always maintain composure, even with challenging customers. Inform a supervisor if a situation escalates.
7. **Interpersonal Respect:** Disrespectful behaviors like eye-rolling, muttering, or talking back are not tolerated. Discussions about customer challenges should be professional and private.
8. **Visitors and Pets:** Visitors and well-behaved pets are allowed occasionally but should not disrupt the work environment.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Sales & Office Procedures

Chapter 16: Dress Code

Factory and office dress code standards. Closed-toed shoes, hairnets for long hair, business casual for office, hygiene expectations.

Factory Dress Code

- Wear neat, appropriate clothing. **Prohibited:** flip-flops, short shorts, revealing tops, dirty attire.
- Shoes must be closed-toed.
- Long hair (shoulder length or more) requires a hairnet.

Office Staff Dress Code

- Business casual is preferred; company logo apparel is encouraged.
- Avoid blue jeans (except payday Fridays), open-toed sandals, tight clothing, T-shirts, and shorts.
- A tidy appearance is required; unkempt dress may lead to being sent home.
- No visible tattoos or facial piercings.
- Hair and facial hair must be well-groomed.
- Good hygiene is essential.
- Use perfume or cologne moderately; avoid strong scents.

Chapter 17: Technology & Data Security

Technology use, remote access, data handling, incident response, software updates, personal device policy. Protect customer data and company systems.

Purpose

To secure and optimize our technology use and data protection.

1. **Technology Use:** Utilize Microsoft Small Business Server, ShopWorks, Slack, Microsoft 365, Adobe Suite, TimeClick, and IP-based phones (GoTo Connect) on Dell desktops with Windows OS 10 or 11.
2. **Remote Access:** Restricted to certain roles, secured via VPN.
3. **Data Handling:** Company and contact data in ShopWorks and CRM, with strict credit card security protocols; no on-premises credit card storage.
4. **Employee Training:** ShopWorks training provided; Microsoft 365 proficiency required.
5. **Incident Response:** Report security incidents immediately to Erik or NP Info.
6. **Software Updates:** Managed by NP Info.
7. **Personal Device Policy:** No personal computers or USB drives due to security concerns.
8. **Monitoring:** Desktops are monitored by NP Info for maintenance and issue resolution.

Chapter 18: Health, Safety & Emergency Procedures

Safe-workplace commitment, hazard reporting, PPE, emergency procedures (fire, medical), assembly point, wellness programs.

Commitment to a Safe Environment

Northwest Custom Apparel is dedicated to maintaining a safe workplace. We strictly adhere to industry-standard safety protocols and expect every employee to contribute to a safe working environment by following all safety guidelines and procedures.

Reporting Hazards

All employees are encouraged to immediately report any unsafe conditions, hazards, or incidents to their supervisor or the safety officer. Prompt reporting can prevent accidents and injuries.

Training and Equipment

We provide necessary safety training and personal protective equipment (PPE) to all employees, particularly those in roles with higher safety risks. Employees must utilize provided training and equipment while performing their duties.

Emergency Procedures

Emergency action plans are in place for different scenarios, including fire, natural disasters, and medical emergencies. These plans are communicated to all employees, and regular drills are conducted to ensure preparedness.

Fire Emergency

- **Fire Extinguishers:** Located throughout the factory and offices. Familiarize yourself with the nearest extinguisher.
- **Evacuation:** Follow the posted evacuation routes.
- **Assembly Point:** Gather in front of our LED Reader board at the corner of **Freeman Rd and 20th Street** so that all employees can be accounted for.
- **Emergency Services:** Immediately dial 911 to report the fire.

Medical Emergency

- **Call 911** for any medical emergency. Provide clear and concise information to the operator.
- **First Aid:** Administer basic first aid if you are trained and it is safe to do so.
- **Incident Reporting:** After the situation is under control, report the incident to your supervisor or to Erik.

Health and Wellness Programs

We prioritize the holistic well-being of our employees. To support this, Northwest Custom Apparel provides a gym membership to **North Hill Fitness** for employees who exercise 2–3 times a week.

For the full operational policy, including PPE specifics, emergency response team structure, and escalation paths, see the Safety & Emergency Procedures policy.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Safety & Emergency Procedures

If You're Hurt at Work — First Aid & Workers' Compensation

1. **Get safe and get care first.** For anything serious, call 911. **First-aid kits are located by the DTG printers and in the embroidery factory.**
 2. **Report it the same shift, no matter how minor** — to your supervisor (production: Ruthie) or to Erik. Cuts, needle sticks, heat-press burns, strains, and near-misses all count; reporting a near-miss is how we fix a hazard before it hurts the next person.
 3. **Workers' compensation (Washington L&I).** NWCA employees are covered by Washington's industrial insurance through the Department of Labor & Industries. If you need medical care: choose any doctor you like, tell them the injury is work-related, and the provider will start your claim (Report of Accident). You can also file yourself at **Ini.wa.gov** or 1-877-561-3453 (1-877-561-FILE).
 4. **We document it.** Erik/accounting records every incident within 24 hours and cooperates fully with L&I on the claim.
 5. **Coming back:** where feasible, NWCA offers light-duty or modified work consistent with your provider's restrictions so you can return sooner.
- No retaliation — ever.** Reporting an injury, a near-miss, or a safety concern, or filing an L&I claim, will never count against you.

Chapter 19: Payroll Information

Pay periods (bi-weekly Friday), wages, overtime, pay advances, salaried employee expectations.

Pay Periods

- Bi-weekly paydays on Fridays via direct deposit.
- Timecards are due the Monday before payday.
- Payment covers the two-week period before the preceding payday.
- Direct deposit payments: notify Erik of bank account changes.

Wages

- Determined by merit, skill level, job responsibilities, attendance, seniority, attitude, and company's financial capacity.
- Higher skill or training levels (artists, machine operators) warrant higher pay.
- Additional skills lead to increased pay rates.

Overtime

- Overtime is paid only for work exceeding 40 hours per week and with prior manager approval.
- Holiday hours don't count as work time; over 8 hours a day doesn't automatically qualify as overtime.
- **Unauthorized overtime is not compensated.**
- Salary discussions are confidential and should only be with your manager.

Pay Advances

- For emergencies and limited to once per year, no more than 50% of your check.
- Deducted automatically from the next paycheck.

Salaried Employees

- Typical work schedule: 40–45 hours per week.
- Employees are eligible for overtime compensation if their salary is below the yearly threshold determined by Washington State.

WA Cares Fund (long-term-care deduction)

WA Cares is Washington's public long-term-care insurance program. The deduction on your paystub — currently 0.58% of gross wages, a rate set by the state — is required by law for most Washington workers. It is not an NWCA charge: employees fund the program entirely, NWCA does not keep any portion, and every dollar goes to the state fund.

- **What you get:** a lifetime long-term-care benefit (available to eligible workers beginning July 2026; roughly \$36,500 at launch, indexed over time) usable for services like in-home caregiving, home-safety equipment, meal support, or facility care.
- **Exemptions:** some workers hold a state-approved exemption — for example, those who opted out with private long-term-care insurance during the 2021–2022 window, certain out-of-state residents, and some veterans. If you have an ESD exemption letter, give a copy to accounting (Bradley); without it on file, NWCA is required to withhold.

Details and benefit rules: wacaresfund.wa.gov.

Chapter 20: Employee Benefits & Programs

Gym membership, professional development, flexible work arrangements, recognition programs, team building, employee suggestions program, referral bonus, employee purchases.

While Northwest Custom Apparel currently does not provide traditional insurance and retirement plan benefits, we are committed to supporting our employees' well-being and work-life balance through various other perks and benefits.

Gym Membership

North Hill Fitness Partnership: To promote physical health and wellness, we have partnered with North Hill Fitness to offer a complimentary gym membership to all our employees who will use it 2–3 times per week. **“If you don’t use it, you lose it.”**

Additional Employee Perks

- **Professional Development:** Workshops, seminars, and online courses are available to help employees enhance their skills and advance their careers.
- **Flexible Work Arrangements:** Flexible work schedules and remote work options for eligible positions. See the Flex Time Policy 2026 for the formal framework.
- **Employee Recognition Programs:** Employee of the year awards, performance bonuses, and celebration of work anniversaries. Tenure-based PTO bonuses per the Flex Time Policy 2026 §4 Recognition Package.
- **Team Building:** Casual team lunches, company outings, and holiday parties.

Employee Suggestions Program

We highly value your insights and ideas for improvement. Share suggestions to enhance productivity, reduce costs, or contribute positively to our work environment with your supervisor.

Rewards

- Recognition through a Letter of Thanks for valuable contributions.
- Monetary rewards for suggestions that lead to significant cost savings or operational improvements.

Referral Program for Hiring Friends

- An employee will receive a bonus of **\$200.00** for each referred friend who completes their 90-day probationary period.
- **Accountability clause:** If a referred individual does not meet our standards and needs to be discharged, the employee who made the referral will be responsible for initiating the termination process.

Employee Purchases

NWCA employees can purchase company apparel from SanMar at a special rate:

1. **Discounted Pricing:** SanMar cost + 10%.
2. **Inbound Freight:** Employee's responsibility.
3. **Sales Tax:** WA state sales tax added.
4. **Payment:** Immediate credit card payment upon receipt; otherwise deducted from next paycheck.

5. **Ordering for Personal Use Only:** Avoid complex orders with multiple styles, colors, and items from different SanMar warehouses.
6. **Ordering Process:** Go to your supervisor to enter the order into ShopWorks.
7. **Ordering Windows:** Quarterly windows; supervisor will inform of exact dates.
8. **Order Limit:** 4 personal orders per employee per year.

Related Policies Hub entries

- [Flex Time Policy 2026](#)

Chapter 21: Performance, Discipline & Termination

Annual performance reviews, training, disciplinary process (progressive discipline), attendance, grievance procedure, feedback mechanism, resignation, and termination.

Annual Performance Reviews

Each year, employees will participate in a comprehensive performance review held in the **first quarter** of the new year. Reviews assess overall work performance, set goals for the upcoming year, and discuss potential areas for growth and development.

- **Preparation:** Before the review, employees will self-assess their performance.
- **Review Meeting:** Managers provide feedback, discuss the self-assessment, and set objectives.
- **Action Plan:** Employee + manager develop an action plan including performance goals, training needs, and career development opportunities.

Performance-Based Raises

- **Merit-Based:** Raises reflect performance, contributions, and alignment with company goals.
- **Budget & Market Conditions:** Salary increases are subject to company budget and market conditions. Raises are not automatic with each review.
- **Alternative Recognition:** When raises aren't feasible, other forms of recognition are explored — bonuses, additional time off, or professional development opportunities.

Training and Professional Development

- **In-House Training:** Regular sessions on technology, customer service, and leadership skills.
- **External Training:** Employees encouraged to participate in external programs. Company may provide flexible scheduling or financial assistance.

Disciplinary Policies

Attendance and Tardiness

- **Expectations:** Be at workstations and ready to work at scheduled start time.
- **Tardiness:** Notify supervisor immediately if late. Habitual tardiness may result in disciplinary action.
- **Absences:** Notify supervisor at least one hour before scheduled start time. Unreported absences may lead to disciplinary action.

Progressive Discipline Process

1. **Verbal Warning:** The first step. Supervisor discusses the issue and expectations.
2. **Written Warning:** If the issue persists, a formal written warning is given.
3. **Final Warning:** Continued issues result in a final warning, clearly stating that failure to improve may lead to termination.
4. **Termination:** If there is no improvement after the final warning, termination may be the final step.

Each case will be evaluated on its own merits, and steps may be skipped depending on the severity of the issue.

Grievance Procedure

1. **Speak with Your Supervisor:** Discuss concerns directly and attempt to resolve informally.

2. **Formal Grievance:** If not resolved, file a formal grievance with Erik Mickelson (HR).
 3. **Investigation and Resolution:** Erik investigates and works toward a fair resolution.
- Retaliation against employees who raise genuine grievances is strictly prohibited.**

Feedback Mechanism

NWCA values team member suggestions and ideas. Channels available:

1. **Direct Email:** Email your supervisor or Erik directly.
2. **In-Person Meetings:** Arrange a meeting with your supervisor and Erik.
3. **Slack Messaging:** Send to Erik and your supervisor via Slack.
4. **Company Meetings:** Share thoughts at all-hands meetings.
5. **Anonymous Suggestions:** Use the physical comment and suggestion box.

Termination of Employment

Resignation Process

1. **Notice Period:** Minimum two weeks' written notice to supervisor and Erik.
2. **Exit Interview:** May be scheduled to discuss experience and feedback.
3. **Return of Company Property:** All company property returned on or before last day.
4. **Final Paycheck:** Issued per regular payroll cycle.

For details on what carries over if a former employee is rehired within 30 days, see the Reinstatement & Rehire Policy.

Termination Policies

1. **Performance-Related Termination:** Progressive discipline process applies. Termination may result if no significant improvement.
2. **Misconduct:** Serious misconduct may result in immediate termination without progressive discipline. Includes theft, violence, severe breach of company policy.
3. **Layoffs or Restructuring:** Company provides as much notice as possible and adheres to legal requirements for severance and benefits.
4. **Final Settlement:** All dues, including final paycheck and other lawful compensations, are cleared per company policy and state laws.

General

- **At-Will Employment:** Either party can end employment at any time, with or without cause or notice.
- **Confidentiality:** Post-termination, former employees are still bound by confidentiality and non-disclosure agreements.

Related Policies Hub entries

- Reinstatement & Rehire Policy — 30-Day Window

Chapter 22: Employee Acknowledgment

Annual acknowledgment that the employee has read and agrees to follow the policies in this handbook. Click-through process at January All-Hands.

Employee Acknowledgment

I confirm receiving the Northwest Custom Apparel Employee Handbook. I agree to read and follow the rules and policies in it. I understand this handbook is not a work contract and can be changed by the company at any time. If I don't understand something in the handbook, I'll ask for clarification and keep myself updated on any changes.

Annual Acknowledgment Process

Each January, all employees will be asked to acknowledge that they have read and understood the current version of this Employee Handbook. This is done via a simple click-through form, and the acknowledgment is recorded with date, employee name, and the handbook version (snapshot ID).

For New Hires

New hires acknowledge the handbook on their first day, signed in writing and filed in their personnel folder.

Signature Block (for offline/PDF version)

Employee Details:

Name: _____

Position: _____

Department: _____

Signature:

I acknowledge that I have received, read, and understood the contents of the Northwest Custom Apparel Employee Handbook.

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____